

Russia: Defense producers hurt by US payment system sanctions

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【メール原文】

New US measures against A7 target the intermediaries that enable Russia's sanctions-busting payment system; banks and Western exporters will de-risk, |||||

Quick take

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US payment system sanctions will hurt Russian defense producers

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What Happened

On 1 October, the US Treasury designated Russia's A7 payment network a transnational criminal organization under its Iran-related sanctions authorities. Financial Crimes Enforcement Network (FinCEN) separately proposed barring US firms from any transaction involving A7's "sub-agents" and will circulate their names to banks privately.

Our Take

The measures leave A7's parent entity untouched but target the network it relied on. A7, which processes about 12% of Russia's foreign trade, and its ruble stablecoin, A7A5, have been under US sanctions since August 2025. Yet A7 continued to operate through intermediaries with access to banking access. FinCEN says the network includes hundreds of such entities, with accounts at more than 400 banks in 83 countries and more than \$17 billion in dollar payments since early 2025.

Keeping the sub-agent list private is the most consequential design choice. A public list lets a network retire flagged entities and stand up replacements before banks can respond. A private list makes that adjustment harder and places the burden on banks. FinCEN wants them to flag multi-jurisdiction payment chains, stablecoin transactions, repeated currency conversions, implausible invoice prices, and documents bearing signs of AI forgery.

Banks will carry the compliance cost, and most will de-risk rather than investigate. Lenders in the EU, Turkey, the UAE, and Central Asia with dollar correspondent relationships are now exposed to a list they cannot see. They are likely to respond by rejecting Russia-adjacent payments wholesale and close accounts of small trading firms.

As a result, Western exporters selling goods to Russia via third countries will likely face more delayed or rejected payments. Chinese state banks were already cautious, so the pressure will fall mainly on the second-tier banks and non-Chinese hubs that A7 relied on.

The sanctions will raise costs for Russia's defense sector. Imports of dual-use goods rely on layered intermediaries, which match the profile FinCEN is targeting. Even before the rule takes effect in 30 days, fees will probably rise above A7's advertised 0.3%, and settlement times will likely stretch from hours to

days.

The measures are unlikely to disrupt military production materially, though Russian defense producers will pay more and face longer delays. Other industries that rely on imported dual-use goods for machinery and technology will also face higher costs, likely contributing to broader inflationary pressures in the economy.

The Iran label is politically convenient. It lets Treasury tighten pressure on Moscow without a Russia-specific decision that would affect the administration's diplomatic efforts. It also gives Kyiv and its allies a stronger case in Washington that Russia's war and Iran's activities are one problem, though that link remains their argument rather than stated US policy.

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